

Asking about prices

Teaching guide

Ask what something costs and clarify the total.

Understand the distinction

Use How much is it? for one item and How much are they? for plural items. With cost as a verb, use does for one item: How much does it cost? The main verb stays in its base form after does.

Ask what the price includes when you need the total. Price, cost, fee, and fare fit different contexts: a course fee, a bus fare. Do not assume that a displayed amount includes every charge.

Compare the patterns

BE

How much is this notebook?

One item takes is.

COST

How much do these tickets cost?

Plural tickets take do.

CLARIFY

Does that include delivery?

Ask what is included in the stated amount.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: How much ___ these shoes?

- A. are
- B. is
- C. does

2. Choose the correction: How much does it costs?

- A. How much does it cost?
- B. How much do it cost?
- C. How much does it costing?

3. Which question asks whether delivery is included in the price?

- A. When will the delivery arrive?
- B. How much does delivery cost?
- C. Does the price include delivery?

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which exchange asks the price and then checks whether delivery is included?

A. How much is the desk? It is eighty dollars. Does that include delivery?

B. How much does the desk costs? It is eighty dollars. Does that include delivery?

C. How much is the desk? It is eighty dollars. Delivery is definitely free.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. are

Shoes is plural.

B: These shoes is plural, so use are.

C: With these shoes, use are, or ask How much do these shoes cost?

2. A. How much does it cost?

Does carries the third-person ending; cost stays in the base form.

B: It takes does, not do.

C: After does, use the base verb cost.

3. C. Does the price include delivery?

The question makes the total clearer.

A: This asks about timing, not what the price includes.

B: This asks the delivery price, not whether it is included.

4. A. How much is the desk? It is eighty dollars. Does that include delivery?

How much asks the price; does that include checks what the price covers.

B: After does, use cost without -s.

C: The last sentence assumes free delivery instead of checking.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-20.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which exchange asks the price and then checks whether delivery is included?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.